PART II · TIME · 4

Time signatures

Two numbers, like a train ticket: the **top number** says how many seats (counts) each bar has; the **bottom number** says which note fills one seat.

THE SECRET

Top number: how many beats. Bottom number: which note gets one beat.

The bottom number

BOTTOM	NOTE	ONE COUNT IS A	FIRST MET
2		minim	Level 3
4		crotchet	Level 0
8		quaver	Level 1
16		semiquaver	*Extra*

Simple time: each beat divides in two

TIME SIGNATURE	EACH BAR HOLDS	FIRST MET
2/4	2 crotchets	Level 0
3/4	3 crotchets	Level 0
4/4 (C)	4 crotchets (the C sign: common time)	Level 0
2/2 (¢)	2 minims (the cut C: cut common time)	Level 3
3/2	3 minims	Level 3
4/2	4 minims	*Extra*
3/8	3 quavers	Level 3

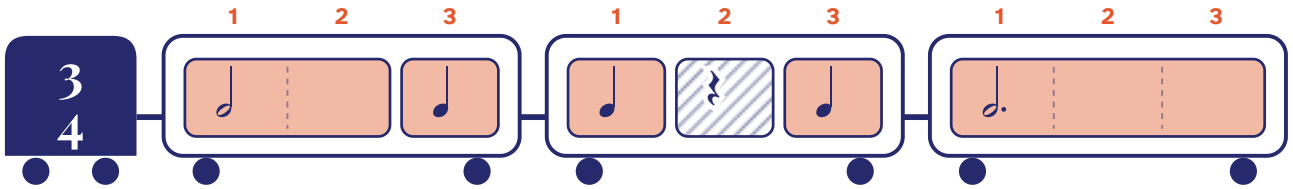
Changing time signature

A new time signature can appear in the middle of a piece, right after a bar line; it holds until the next one. A time signature is written only once, not on every line.

PART II · TIME · 4 · CONTINUED

Think of a train

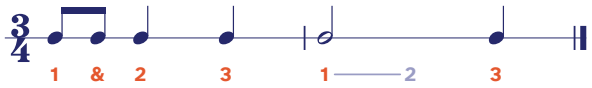
In 3/4 every carriage (bar) has exactly **3 seats**; each seat is one crotchet beat. Notes book seats: a minim takes 2, a crotchet 1. A rest books a seat and leaves it **empty** (shaded). Every seat in every carriage must be booked.



minim + crotchet · crotchet, crotchet rest, crotchet · dotted minim: 3 seats each

EXAMPLE

Read a time signature
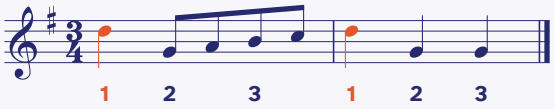


1. **Top number 3:** three counts in each bar.
2. **Bottom number 4:** a crotchet is one count.
3. **Check a bar:** two quavers + crotchet + crotchet = 3.

3/4: **three crotchet beats** in every bar.

YOU KNOW THIS

Minuet in G (from the Notebook for Anna Magdalena Bach)



Every bar holds **three crotchet beats**: 1 2 3, 1 2 3, the step of the dance. That is 3/4.

Try it. Count 1 2 3 aloud while someone plays it.

TRAP

- × Reading the bottom number as a count: it names the note that gets one beat.
- × Reading 6/8 as six beats: at most speeds it moves in two.
- × Mixing up 3/4 and 6/8: both hold six quavers, grouped differently (p. 43).

SEE ALSO

Pulse and the bar p. 34 · Compound time p. 43

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Level 0 · Time signatures · Online: Library › Time signatures